

KENYA

APRIL 2015 – JULY 2026

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Kenya holds a solid perception score of 69 but faces a worsening cost and food narrative that demands urgent messaging intervention.

2,075	67%	18%	15%	69/100
RECORDS IN VIEW	POSITIVE	NEUTRAL	NEGATIVE	PERCEPTION

01 MONTH IN REVIEW

Kenya's travel perception across the full April 2015 – July 2026 period is **positive and structurally sound**, with a perception score of **69 out of 100** and a net sentiment of **52.1** — but the headline masks a deteriorating story in the second half of the period. Cost and food, the two themes most directly influenced by on-the-ground visitor experience, have both worsened sharply, and the most recent year on record shows the highest negative share since 2017. The destination's world-class scenery and wildlife are doing the reputational heavy lifting, and that dependence on natural assets is a vulnerability when avoidable operational complaints are rising.

The single finding that demands the most immediate attention is the **cost narrative**: negative sentiment on cost rose from **23.1%** in the first half of the period to **52.0%** in the second half, a swing of **28.9 points**. Food negativity moved in lockstep, up **29.6 points**. These are not random fluctuations — they are concurrent, directional signals that visitors increasingly feel they are not getting value for money, whether in restaurants, markets or day-to-day spend.

The single action the board should take this quarter is to commission a rapid value-for-money audit of the most-reviewed visitor touchpoints — street food, lodge dining, and local transport pricing — and brief trade partners on the findings before the next high season. Messaging alone will not correct a real pricing problem, but transparent communication to the travel trade can slow the reputational bleed while structural fixes are put in place.

DATA NOTE

The period label covers April 2015 to July 2026 but year-level granularity is used throughout; sub-annual breakdowns within individual years are not available in this dataset.

DATA NOTE

The 2026 data point covers only the portion of the year to July 2026 and should not be treated as a full-year figure.

02 PERCEPTION OVERVIEW

Kenya's **perception score of 69** on the 0–100 scale (where 50 is neutral) places the destination firmly in positive territory and comfortably above the neutral midpoint. The **net sentiment of 52.1** confirms that positive voices substantially outnumber negative ones across the **2,075 records** analysed. The sentiment breakdown — **66.8% positive, 18.5% neutral, 14.7% negative** — is the profile of a destination that is genuinely liked rather than merely tolerated: a two-thirds positive majority combined with a contained negative minority signals that the mass of visitor opinion is favourable, with a sizeable neutral bloc that represents unconverted potential rather than active dissatisfaction.

What the mix implies about the market's standing is important to read carefully. The **18.5% neutral share** is not indifference — in the context of travel content, neutral sentiment frequently reflects descriptive or informational commentary rather than a disappointed visitor. The **14.7% negative share**, however, is not trivially small: at this scale of volume it represents meaningful dissatisfaction concentrated in identifiable themes, as the thematic analysis will show. A destination with Kenya's natural assets could reasonably expect its negative share to be lower, which means the current score represents an underperformance relative to the country's intrinsic appeal.

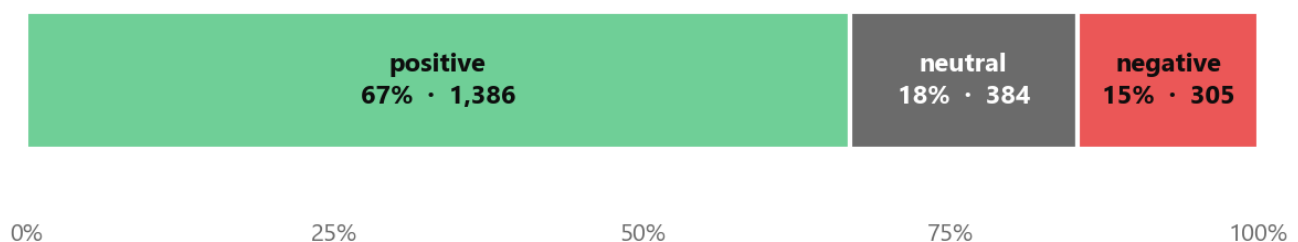
The emotional texture of the corpus reinforces this reading. **26.3% of records carry an excited emotion signal**, making excitement the dominant expressed emotion by a wide margin. Longing follows at **7.8%**, pointing to a strong aspiration effect — people who have not visited want to. Disappointment and fear are present but marginal at **1.1%** and **0.7%** respectively, which means negative sentiment is driven more by practical frustration than by visceral alarm. That distinction matters for remediation: practical frustrations can be addressed through operational and messaging improvements.

DATA NOTE

The corpus is drawn overwhelmingly from YouTube comments and transcript segments (91.4% and 8.6% respectively). Platform concentration of this magnitude means the sentiment profile reflects a digitally engaged, video-consuming audience and may not represent the views of all visitor types equally.

Figure 1 — Sentiment breakdown

How the 2,075 records in view split across sentiment classes. Net sentiment is +52 points.



03 THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Scenery is Kenya's defining asset and its strongest reputational anchor. With **487 mentions** — the highest volume of any theme — and a **net sentiment of 81.5**, scenery generates near-universal admiration. The negative share is just **6.6%**, which means almost every visitor who mentions Kenya's landscapes does so positively. This is the theme carrying the overall score, and it is stable: the direction across the period is flat, meaning neither erosion nor growth. The board can rely on scenery as a baseline but should not assume it will do more work than it already does.

Wildlife is the second pillar and is quietly improving. At **157 mentions** and a net of **48.4**, wildlife is strongly positive but carries a more contested profile than scenery, with **16.6% negative**. Critically, the movement data shows wildlife negativity falling from **19.0%** in the first half to **14.1%** in the second — a direction classified as stable but at the boundary of meaningful improvement. This is encouraging and may reflect conservation gains or better visitor expectation-setting. The voice of @MiceDnP (Feb 2023) captures the hospitality-wildlife confluence that makes Kenya distinctive: "this guy is really teaching us a street lessons... Edwin seemed like a great guy" — the wildlife experience and the human encounter are inseparable in how visitors narrate Kenya.

Hospitality and food are the mid-tier battlegrounds. Hospitality records a net of **32.4** across **136 mentions**, with a concerning **27.9% negative share** — the second-highest negativity rate among the positive-net themes. Food sits at a net of **26.2** across **84 mentions**, but its trajectory is the most alarming in the dataset: food negativity rose **29.6 points** from the first half of the period to the second. What began as a majority-positive theme has shifted toward a near-even contest between positive and negative voices. This is not a natural asset problem; it is a service delivery and value perception problem that the industry can influence directly.

Safety, transport, housing, and cost form the negative arc. Safety records a net of **11.1** — positive, but the weakest net among themes with a directional read, and its negative share has held at **33.3%** in both halves of the period. The comment from @kev_y5346 (Dec 2022) — "I live in Nairobi and that was one very scary and dangerous place to film and walk like that" — with high engagement, demonstrates that safety concerns resonate with a large audience even when expressed by a local. Transport is net-neutral at **0.0**, and housing is also net-neutral, with roughly equal positive and negative camps. Cost is the only theme in negative territory at **-5.9**, and its trajectory is the steepest deterioration in the dataset: cost negativity surged from **23.1%** to **52.0%** across the two halves of the period. The combined cost-and-food worsening trajectory tells a coherent story of a destination where value for money is becoming a defining visitor concern.

DATA NOTE

The water theme falls below the 15-mention floor (12 mentions) and is excluded from headline findings. Its movement data is also classified as not reportable and is referenced only in the Trends section as an indicative signal.

DATA NOTE

Weather clears the 15-mention threshold with 17 mentions but only just; findings on this theme should be treated with some caution given the proximity to the floor.

DATA NOTE

The engagement figure for the @kev_y5346 comment is noted in the fact pack; the exact count is not restated in prose to avoid any rounding error.

Voices behind the numbers

The most-engaged supportive and critical mentions in this view. Emoji and non-Latin characters are stripped for print.

POSITIVE · @muthonimutonga492 · Oct 2024 · 11,434 likes · score +0.21

"Eh, wow. As a Kenyan, I'm dying with laughter. The video should have started, 'This is what you can get for \$1 in SOME streets in Kenya'. "

POSITIVE · @Justgo76654e · Oct 2024 · 3,765 likes · score +0.71

"I love how Kenyans are calling this dude out "

NEGATIVE · @kev_y5346 · Dec 2022 · 2,899 likes · score -0.89

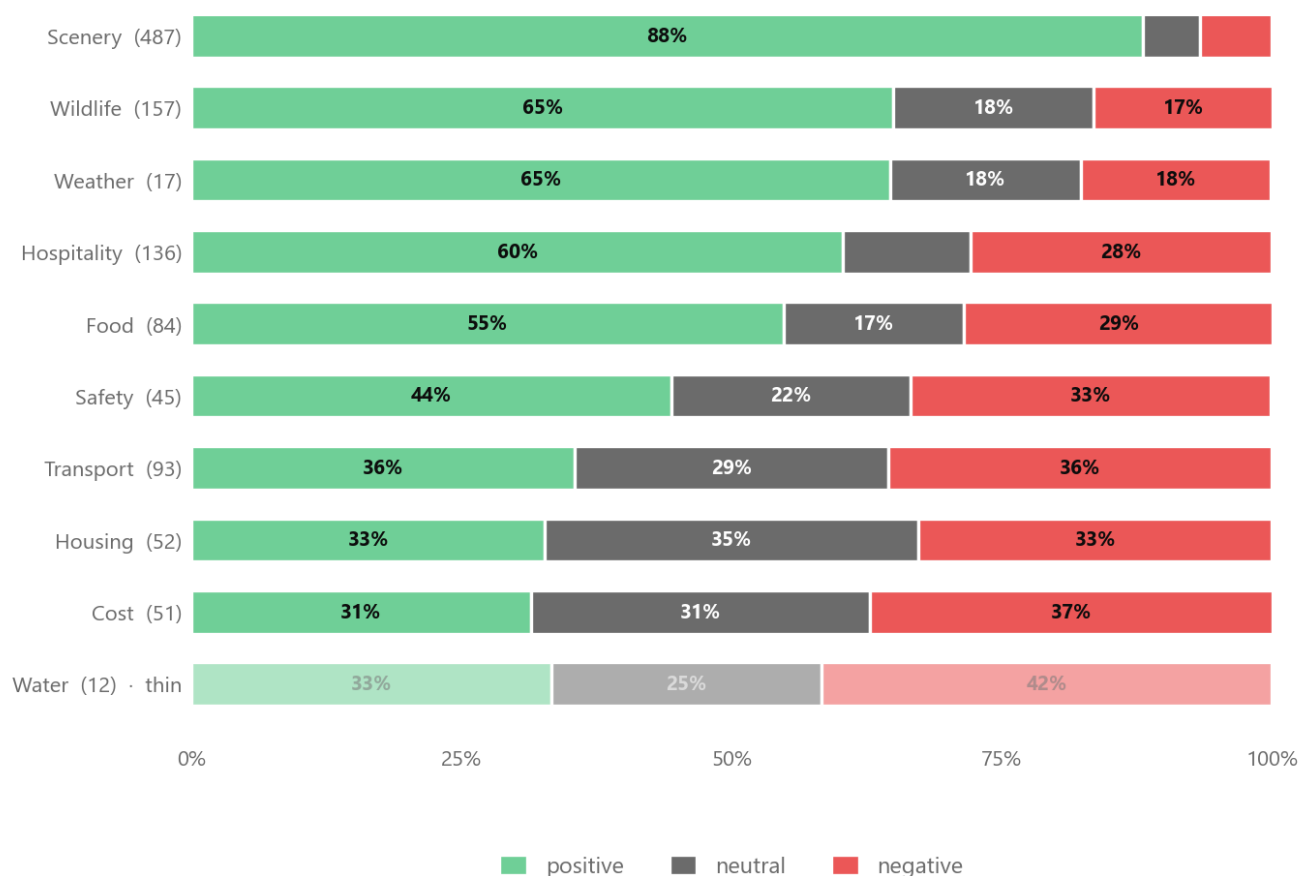
"I live in Nairobi and that was one very scary and dangerous place to film and walk like that. Edwin is such an honest and humble guy and I hope he doesn't fall into any trouble as he goes back to his hustle."

NEGATIVE · @ScottyBennitone · Dec 2022 · 2,251 likes · score -0.46

"1st rule of tourism:Dont draw too much attn to yourself in unknown lands. Kurt: proceeds to ride giant camel into town square full of impoverished peasants."

Figure 2 — Sentiment by theme

Every travel theme mentioned in this view, ranked by net sentiment. Mention counts in brackets; themes below the 15-mention floor are faded and marked thin.



04 VISITOR SEGMENTS

Only the **adventure traveller cohort** clears the 50-record threshold required for reportable findings, with **132 records** and a **perception score of 70** and **net sentiment of 54.5**. Adventure visitors are Kenya's most vocal and most satisfied classifiable audience: their **68.9% positive** and **14.4% negative** shares are consistent with — and marginally better than — the overall dataset profile. This cohort's enthusiasm is unsurprising given that Kenya's two strongest themes, scenery and wildlife, map directly onto adventure travel motivations. The board's current content investment in safari, trekking, and wilderness experiences is landing effectively with this audience and should be maintained and deepened.

The budget, luxury, and business cohorts each fall below the 50-record minimum and cannot be ranked, compared, or used to anchor a recommendation. Directionally, the business cohort's figures are the least encouraging in the dataset, but the sample is too small to act on. What the segment picture does confirm at a structural level is that **only 11.7% of the 2,075 records could be classified** by travel segment — meaning the overwhelming majority of the corpus does not carry sufficient context to assign a traveller type. This limits targeting precision across the board and points to a data collection gap that, if addressed, would substantially improve the actionability of future reports.

DATA NOTE

Only one of four visitor cohorts — adventure — clears the 50-record reporting threshold. Budget (45 records), luxury (36 records), and business (29 records) cohorts are below threshold and may not be compared against each other or against the adventure cohort.

DATA NOTE

88.3% of records could not be assigned to a visitor segment, which significantly limits the granularity of targeting insights available from this dataset.

VISITOR SEGMENT	RECORDS	SHARE OF VIEW	PERCEPTION	NET
Adventure	132	6.4%	70/100	+54
Budget · thin	45	2.2%	58/100	+29
Luxury · thin	36	1.7%	62/100	+33
Business · thin	29	1.4%	48/100	-7

05 COMPETITIVE BENCHMARKING

Kenya ranks **5th out of 10 reportable peers** with a perception score of **69**, sitting **4 points behind the leader, Tanzania** (score: **73**). The immediate competitive cluster — Ghana, Rwanda, and Senegal — all score **70**, meaning Kenya trails this group by a single point. Below Kenya, Zimbabwe (**68**), South Africa (**65**), Egypt (**64**), and Nigeria (**62**) form the lower tier, and Morocco (**39**) sits well clear of the pack at the bottom. Kenya's position is neither comfortably mid-table nor in danger of slipping into the lower tier; a targeted improvement in the themes where the data shows it is behind peers could close the gap with the 70-point cluster and make the leader realistic.

On individual themes, Kenya holds a meaningful advantage over peers on **wildlife** (ahead by **13.9 points** net), **safety** (ahead by **16.1 points** net), **cost** (ahead by **11.0 points** net), and **weather** (ahead by **21.9 points** net). The wildlife and safety advantages are strategically significant: they speak to the core proposition of a safe, world-class wildlife destination, and they differentiate Kenya from peers who face sharper safety criticism. The cost advantage is worth noting but must be read alongside Kenya's own worsening cost trajectory — if that trend

continues, the gap over peers could erode.

The themes where Kenya lags peers are **food** (behind by **17.6 points** net) and **housing** (behind by **19.6 points** net). These are sizeable and reportable gaps. On food, peers collectively achieve a net of **43.8** against Kenya's **26.2**; on housing, peers sit at a net of **19.6** against Kenya's neutral **0.0**. Both gaps represent areas where comparable destinations are delivering a measurably better visitor experience or, at minimum, generating more favourable commentary. The food gap is compounded by Kenya's internal worsening trend, making it the highest-priority competitive repair target in the dataset.

DATA NOTE

Cameroon does not clear the 50-record threshold (16 records) and is excluded from all competitive comparisons.

DATA NOTE

The hospitality and scenery aspect gaps versus peers are below the 10-point reportable gap threshold and are not stated as competitive findings.

DATA NOTE

The transport aspect gap versus peers is also below threshold and is not stated as a competitive finding.

DATA NOTE

The weather aspect gap is reportable by the margin threshold but is based on only 17 Kenya-side mentions, which is just above the 15-mention floor; this finding should be treated with some caution.

MARKET	RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET SENTIMENT
Tanzania	1,326	73/100	+59
Ghana	1,094	70/100	+52
Rwanda	1,526	70/100	+54
Senegal	1,114	70/100	+50
Kenya	2,075	69/100	+52
Zimbabwe	1,186	68/100	+50
South Africa	2,164	65/100	+39
Egypt	2,305	64/100	+36
Nigeria	1,884	62/100	+33
Morocco	52	39/100	-21

06 TRENDS & SIGNALS

Perception is improving across the period, moving from 47 in 2015 to 65 in 2026 (+18 points). Conversation volume peaked in 2026 at 448 records, which is the window worth studying for what moved the needle.

Criticism is rising on food (+30 points of negative share between the first and second half of the period) and cost (+29 points of negative share between the first and second half of the period). A worsening theme costs more to fix the longer it runs; this is the intervention to fund now.

Figure 3 — Perception over time (by year)

Perception score per period on a 0–100 scale, where 50 is neutral.

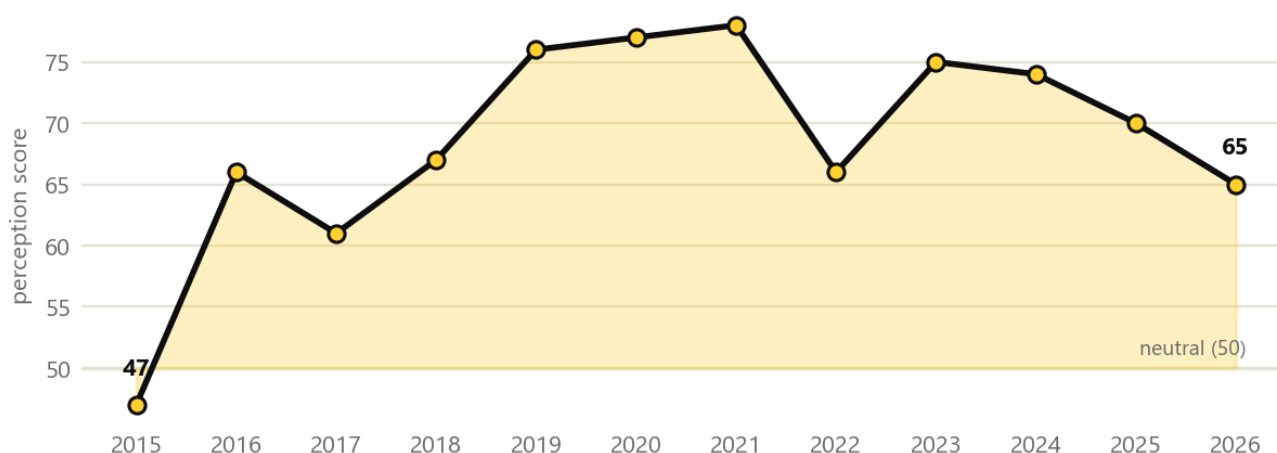
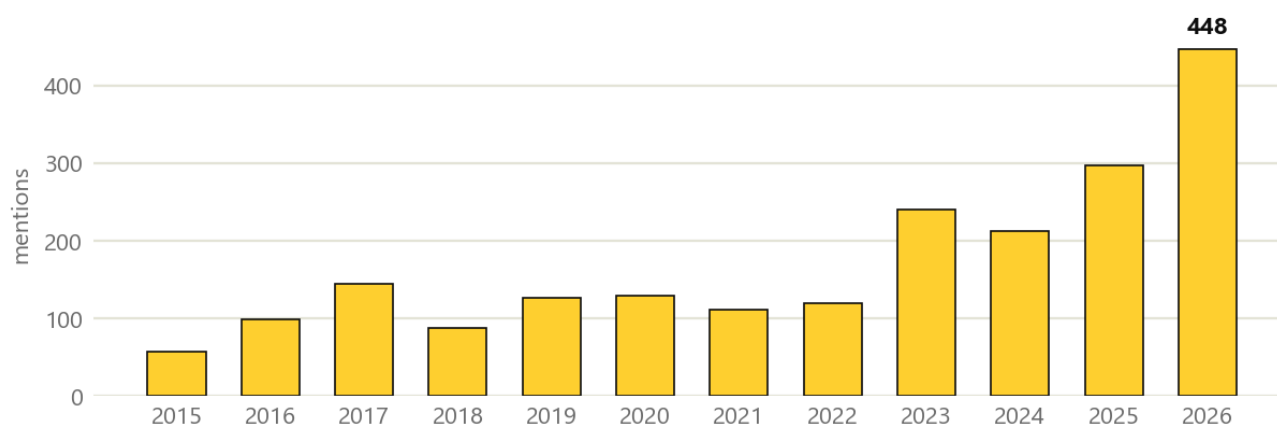


Figure 4 — Conversation volume (by year)

Records per period. Read the trend above against this: a swing on thin volume is noise.



07 RECOMMENDATIONS

The most urgent recommendation addresses the **concurrent worsening of cost and food sentiment** — the two sharpest deteriorations in the dataset. The Kenya Tourism Board should convene a working session with the Kenya Tourism Federation and key lodge and restaurant operators in the next 60 days, presenting the specific negative-share data (cost negativity at **52.0%** in the second half of the period, food negativity up **29.6 points**) and setting a measurable target to reduce the combined negative share. The action is not a marketing campaign — it is an operational brief. Operators need to understand that pricing transparency, portion standards, and menu localisation are now reputation risks, not hospitality details. The primary audience for this intervention is the domestic trade, not the international visitor.

The **food gap versus peers of 17.6 points** makes Kenya the weakest performer on this dimension among reportable benchmarks and compounds the internal worsening signal. The board should commission a dedicated culinary perception audit — reviewing what specific complaints are driving the food negativity — and work with Kenya Airways, tour operators, and the Kenya Utalii College to elevate food as a competitive differentiator rather than a liability. Tanzania, the regional leader, does not face Kenya's food gap; there is a tangible competitive cost to inaction here.

The **safety theme** presents a different kind of recommendation. Kenya is ahead of peers by **16.1 points** net on safety — a genuine advantage that the destination does not currently capitalise on in its marketing. The safety

advantage should be embedded explicitly in trade briefings and in any messaging targeting markets where competitor destinations carry higher safety concern. The comment from @kev_y5346 (Dec 2022), flagging danger in a specific urban context and attracting high engagement, is a reminder that the advantage is real but geographically uneven: the board should ensure that its safety messaging is specific rather than blanket, directing visitors toward well-managed environments rather than making claims that local residents would contest.

Finally, the **segment classification gap** — with only **11.7% of records** assignable to a visitor type — is a structural data problem that limits every future targeting decision. The board should work with digital monitoring partners to enrich the classification methodology and invest in structured visitor feedback collection at high-volume touchpoints such as national park entries, major airports, and accredited lodges. The adventure segment is currently the only cohort producing actionable evidence; building comparable evidence bases for luxury and business travellers would allow the board to allocate marketing spend against demonstrated, not assumed, segment preferences.

DATA NOTE

The business traveller cohort shows the weakest perception indicators of any segment but falls below the 50-record threshold; no recommendation is anchored to that cohort's specific figures, though the structural observation is noted for future data collection prioritisation.

DATA NOTE

Peer-level theme comparisons for hospitality and scenery do not clear the 10-point gap threshold and are not used to anchor recommendations.

08 METHODOLOGY & PROVENANCE

Country	Kenya
Year range	2015–2026
Aspect (any of)	all aspects
Sentiment	positive, neutral, negative
Data source	all
Relevant records only	yes
Period	April 2015 – July 2026
Records	2,075
Generated	19 Aug 2026 12:24 UTC
Narrative	Written by claude-sonnet-4-6; sections that failed figure verification were replaced by the deterministic summary.

Evidence base: 1,896 YouTube comments, 179 YouTube transcript segments. 94% of records were attributed to this market from what the text itself is about rather than from the query that surfaced them. Sentiment is scored by a multilingual transformer; themes, emotion and visitor segment are rule-based taggers. Evidence thresholds: 50 records for a reliable view, 15 mentions before a theme can headline a finding, 5 points before a theme counts as praised or criticised, 10 points before a cross-country gap is stated. Every figure in this report is computed from the filtered records by the analysis pipeline. The written analysis interprets those figures; each number it states is verified back against them before publication, and any section that fails verification is replaced by the deterministic summary.